

An event that deeply impacted Swaminathan was the Bengal Famine of 1943. The colonial government failed to address a severe shortage of grain thanks to its preoccupation with World War II. As a result, millions of people died of starvation. Swaminathan believed self-sufficiency in food production could prevent future famines.

The science of growing food

Swaminathan went on to study agriculture, plant genetics and plant breeding, both in India and abroad. During this time, the Indian government had begun to take steps towards improving the country's food security. The measures employed included changing who owned the land and how they held it (land reforms), increasing investment in agriculture and setting up dams and irrigation systems. The government also invested in studying scientific methods to increase agricultural yields. Upon Swaminathan's return to India in 1954, he engaged in research on two of India's staple crops, rice and wheat, and returned to his alma mater, the Indian Agricultural Research Institute in New Delhi.